Black Cultural Centre – Challenge Kickoff Notes

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Context

The transcript is rough, so obvious transcription errors are corrected here (for example, "Mygma" → Mi'kmaq, "Bolta" → Volta). Uncertain spots are flagged.

- **Event:** a challenge kickoff hosted at Volta, Atlantic Canada's AI startup hub, with mentors from RBC. Two community partners each presented a problem statement. The second, Coastal Action's fish video analysis, is not ours, so everything about fish, eDNA and electrofishing can be ignored.
- **Presenter:** the BCC's assistant director (name garbled in the transcript, something like Rayelle Simone Williams). She has worked there 13 years and was filling in for CEO Russell Grosse.
- **About the BCC:** a museum, archive, research hub, and educational and cultural institution on Highway 7. Its mission is to protect, promote and preserve African Nova Scotian history and culture. It was founded in 1983.
- **Written brief coming:** she said teams will receive a document with the problem statement, essentially what she read aloud, including key partner locations. That document will be the most reliable source.

The problem statement

The BCC wants to build a **history knowledge hub**: a trusted discovery gateway that helps people find credible resources about African Nova Scotian and African Canadian history. Those resources are held by museums, archives, universities and community collections across Canada.

The core issue is that many organizations hold this material, but they aren't connected. To find anything today, you have to already know where to look and exactly what you're searching for. There's no place to browse, explore, and discover what exists and who holds it.

Why it matters to her personally: she went to high school right near the BCC and never learned about it. She feels schools failed to connect people to this history. On a recent trip to the Canadian Museum for Human Rights in Winnipeg, she realized many organizations are doing similar work without knowing about each other.

Constraints and requirements

1. **Tiny staff.** There are only 8 people, so the BCC can't take on heavy cataloguing or maintenance on top of its regular programming. The solution has to be low-effort for them to run.
2. **No ownership claims.** The hub must not appear to own partners' materials. It should point users to the holding institution, acting as a connector or referral layer, not a repository.
3. **Consistent language.** The same person, place or topic may be named differently across institutions, and there are multiple languages. The hub needs to reconcile these and avoid duplicates.
4. **User-friendly and public-facing.** She confirmed it should be fully accessible to the public.
5. **Easy onboarding for all partner sizes.** It should work for both large institutions and small community organizations, and be affordable.
6. **Copyright and access.** Some partner material has copyright or access restrictions, so the hub may need to respect institutional access rules or registration requirements.

What exists today (from the Q&A)

- **BCC's own catalogue:** an in-house archive using CollectiveAccess, likely through the shared Nova Scotia museums system. The transcript's "theographus size" is probably NovaMuse, the public collections site, but this needs verifying. Staff enter records manually, including accession numbers.
- **Public but hard to search:** the catalogue is publicly viewable, but you have to know what you're looking for. Some BCC records require a request for access, to protect sensitive information.
- **Legacy records:** a large backlog dates to 1983 and earlier. Much of it was handwritten before modern cataloguing systems and is still being digitized.
- **External sources:** yes, she wants to pull in or point to external organizations across Canada.

- **Openness:** she wants things as available as possible. Black history was historically poorly preserved, and the BCC doesn't want to gatekeep. They can still provide physical originals on request, for example if someone finds a photo through the hub.
- **Partners:** the BCC has a large existing network across Canada. Partners fall naturally into categories: universities, museums, community organizations, and individual knowledge holders. These categories could be a useful way to structure the hub.
- **Website:** the BCC's current site is basic organizational info. The hub would be separate but linked from it. There was a mention of a digital museum.

What this points to for our team

The ask is essentially a **federated discovery or directory layer**, not a new archive. Directions worth considering:

- A directory of partner institutions, with what each holds, topics covered, and how to access it.
- Search that spans several partner catalogues, with results linking out to the source institution.
- A shared vocabulary or alias list, so different names for the same person, place or community resolve together. This is a natural fit for AI assistance.
- A low-effort way for small partners to submit or update their listings, so the 8-person BCC isn't doing all the data entry.
- Clear attribution on every result showing who owns and holds it.

Questions to bring to mentors or the BCC

- [ ] Which partner institutions should the first version include?
- [ ] Do any partners have APIs or exportable catalogues, or will the data be collected manually?
- [ ] Who maintains the hub long-term, and what's the budget? (A budget question was asked at the session, but the answer was inaudible.)
- [ ] How should restricted or sensitive records appear in search results?
- [ ] Are there community or cultural protocols around certain materials, such as family records, oral histories or photos of individuals?